

Copilot Prompt Handout — Session 2

Microsoft 365 Copilot Agents

Audience: Copilot licensed users. Demo files referenced are fictional and provided in the session pack.

How to use this handout

Use these prompts during or after the session to practise common Copilot scenarios. Each is grouped by use case so you can quickly find a starting point.

- Copy a prompt as-is, then adapt the names and details to your own work.
- Add business context when you want a sharper answer (role, audience, what 'good' looks like).
- Always validate facts, figures and wording before you share.

Tip: stronger prompts usually include a goal, context, a source, the output you expect, and a request to validate.

Choosing a prompt by pace — most demos below give a few options: A · Quick (low interaction / short on time) lands the point in one shot. B · Standard (balanced) is the core demo. C · Interactive (high engagement) is multi-part — invite the class to shape the inputs, refine, and compare.

1. Sharpen your prompt (agents run on instructions)

The four parts that make a great prompt make a great agent.

Four-part prompt

Goal: what I want and in what format.
Context: who it's for and any background.
Source: which files or data to use.
Expectations: length, tone, and what to do if unsure.

2. Use the Researcher agent

Deep, multi-step research with sources.

Option A · Quick — one-shot

Research the main risks of a finance operating-model redesign and give me five bullet points with sources.

Option B · Standard — structured brief

Research the typical risks and success factors for a finance operating-model redesign in professional services. Summarize into key risks, leading practices, and three questions I should ask a client. Show your sources.

Option C · Interactive — pick the angle

I'm preparing for a client conversation on a finance operating-model redesign. Research the topic, then give me key risks, leading practices, and three discovery questions — and ask me which area to go deeper on before pulling more detail with sources.

3. Use the Analyst agent

Reasoning over your data — point it at the demo portfolio.

Option A · Quick — one question

Using this engagement portfolio, which service line has the lowest average margin this quarter? Show the supporting rows.

Option B · Standard — drivers + chart

Using this engagement portfolio, what is driving the change in margin? Focus on budget variance, hours vs. plan, and engagements past their original end date. Show the supporting rows, flag the top 3 outliers, and chart margin by service line.

Option C · Interactive — readout drill-down

Using this engagement portfolio, help me prepare a partner readout. Start with the three biggest patterns I should know, then ask me which one to drill into – show the rows, quantify the impact, and suggest one action.

4. Build a no-code agent (Describe, then build on it in Configure)

Describe the agent and let Copilot draft it — then use Configure to layer on what the draft can't know: your knowledge, your house rules, and the guardrails.

Step 1 — Describe (start here)

Create an agent that helps our professional-services team turn meeting notes and status updates into clear, client-ready summaries. When I give it a meeting transcript or a few status notes, it should produce a short summary, the key decisions, the action items with owners and due dates, and a brief client-ready update of about 100-120 words in a professional tone. Call it "Engagement Update Assistant".

Step 2 — Review what Copilot drafts (it will look roughly like this)

You are Engagement Update Assistant, a helpful assistant for a professional-services team. When the user shares a meeting transcript or status notes, produce:

- 1) a short summary
- 2) the key decisions
- 3) the action items with owners and due dates
- 4) a brief client-ready update of about 100-120 words

Keep a professional, friendly tone and be concise. If you are unsure, ask the user to clarify.

Step 3 — Configure: build on the draft (add what it can't know)

Add knowledge: attach the Quarterly Business Review and the leadership transcript, so the agent uses our real engagement names, terminology and tone instead of generic guesses. Pin the format: always return the four sections in order, and render the action items as a table – Action | Owner | Due | Status. If a due date is missing, leave it blank and ask me – never invent one.

Guard the numbers: if the source mentions a figure or percentage, quote it exactly and add a 'please verify' note. Do not calculate or estimate.

Set scope: summarize and draft only – no legal, tax or contractual advice; if asked, say it's out of scope and point to the engagement lead.

Protect the client view: in the client-ready update, never include internal-only details (margins, staffing, internal risks) unless I confirm. Lead with the decision, then the

status.

Match house style: British English, concise and confident, no jargon.

Step 4 — Replace the generic starters with your real tasks

- 1) Summarize this steering-committee transcript into decisions and actions.
- 2) Draft a client-ready update from these status notes.
- 3) What follow-ups are assigned to me this week?

5. Test your agent

Check it against a real input before you rely on it.

Option A · Quick — one clean test

Here is a meeting transcript. Produce the summary, decisions and actions exactly as your instructions specify, and flag anything you're unsure about.

Option B · Thorough — add a messy input

Test the agent twice: first with this full transcript, then with a short, messy status note that's missing a due date — check that it asks for the missing detail instead of guessing, and tell me anything it got wrong.

6. Share responsibly

Permissions always apply — sharing never widens access.

Sharing check

Before I share this agent, list what knowledge it uses and confirm it only draws on content the recipients can already access.